

Moving north from Knoxville, Smith would retake the Cumberland Gap and join with Bragg in an invasion of Kentucky. But Smith then decided that the Gap was too strongly defended to take by assault, so without consulting Bragg, he chose to bypass it. Smith took an unopposed route to Kentucky instead, routing Union forces at Richmond on August 30. Braxton Bragg, racing to catch up, left Chattanooga on August 28 and crossed into Kentucky. Advancing toward Louisville, Bragg's progress was delayed by a Union garrison at Munfordville, which held out for three days before surrendering. This gave Buell enough time to hurry back to defend Kentucky.

Like Lee's invasion of Maryland, the Confederate offensive had been based on the assumption that local people would greet the invaders as a liberation force. Bragg brought with him rifles to arm thousands of Kentucky volunteers. He also brought the state's Confederate governor, Richard Hawes, who was formally inaugurated in the state capital, Frankfort, on October 4. But it became obvious that the state's enthusiasm for the South had been exaggerated when the volunteers never materialized.

ORPHAN BRIGADE The name given to the Confederate 1st Kentucky Brigade, possibly because of the brigade's forced exile from its home state.

The Battle of Perryville

Meanwhile, goaded by Lincoln, Buell had advanced from Louisville on October 1. Hawes's inauguration ceremony at Frankfort was ruined as the town came under attack by the Union. By this time the South should have concentrated their forces, but Bragg's army was based at Bardstown while Smith's was some 60 miles (97km) away at Lexington. The campaign's key battle was fought before the two could unite.

While away at Frankfort for the inauguration, Bragg left his army at Bardstown under the command of General Leonidas Polk. Confronted by three columns of Buell's army advancing on him on October 7, Polk fell back to Perryville on the Chaplin River. A drought had struck Kentucky and the marching Union troops were desperate for drinking water—which the Confederates controlled. A